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Centering Community Voices in Climate Solutions

Abstract

Climate and health programs are often designed without asking the people they are meant to help. Researchers at Harvard Chan C-CHANGE, led by Shoba Ramanadhan, are changing that by bringing community engagement and implementation science into climate and health research. Working with partners in Massachusetts and India, they help communities define the problems, decide what success looks like, and build solutions that last.

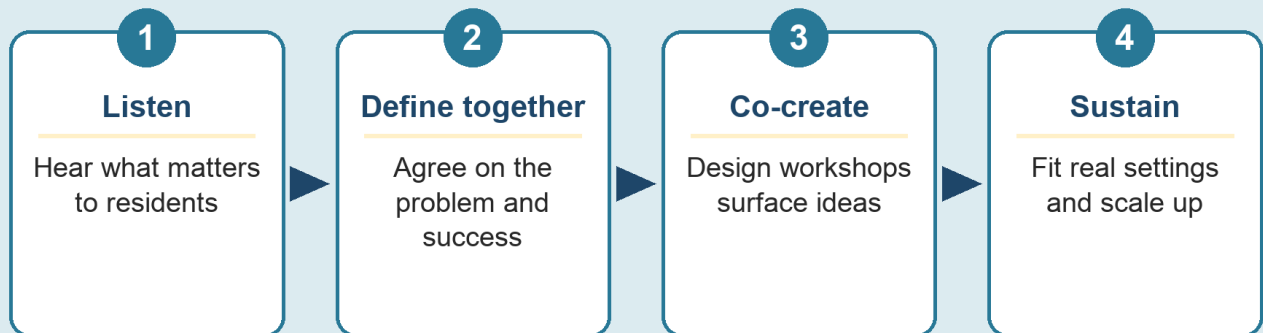
Introduction

Imagine designing a heat safety program for a neighborhood without ever talking to the people who live there. You might choose the wrong location for a cooling center, write messages in the wrong language, or miss the problem residents care about most. Too often, climate and health interventions are created this way, and they fail to meet communities' real needs. This is especially true for groups that have been historically excluded from decision-making, including racial minorities, Tribal populations, LGBTQ+ groups, and people in low-resource settings. This research aims to put those most affected by climate change at the center of designing the solutions.

How Do Scientists Study This?

The team combines two approaches. Community engagement brings residents and local organizations into every stage of research as partners, not just participants. Implementation science studies how to make proven solutions work in real-world settings, making sure that practice-based expertise, the knowledge of people doing the work, shapes the solutions. Together, these methods help researchers and organizations co-create solutions with communities. The team uses user-centered design workshops, where participants explore problems, share ideas, and test solutions together. For example, they have worked to weave topics like climate anxiety into existing youth health programs and to make conversations about climate change a routine part of public health.

Community-centered research



Define the problem together

Community members help decide what the problem is and what success would look like.

Co-create solutions

User-centered design workshops draw out local expertise and ideas for change.

Build to last

Implementation science helps solutions fit real settings so they can be sustained and scaled.

What Did They Discover?

The team's approach aims for change at both the individual and community levels, with an eye toward lasting systems change. It recognizes that community means different things in different places. One key product is a playbook for user-centered research design, which the researchers describe as a kind of recipe book. It offers practical frameworks, workshop structures, activity ideas, and real-world examples so research teams can run creative, community-led sessions. It is meant to be flexible rather than prescriptive and to grow with user feedback. The researchers argue that when solutions start from the ground up, they are more likely to scale and succeed in similar communities everywhere.

The project at a glance

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countries with community partners: U.S. and India

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historically excluded groups named as a focus

1

open playbook for user-centered research design

The project works with community-based organizations in both Massachusetts and India and connects with practitioners worldwide.

Takeaways

Ask first

Solutions built without community input may not meet people's real needs.

Everyone is an expert

Residents and practitioners bring knowledge that researchers need.

Ground-up scales

Community-led solutions are more likely to last and spread to other places.

Key Terms

Community engagement

Involving community members as partners in planning, carrying out, and using research.

Implementation science

The study of how to put proven solutions into practice so they work in real-world settings.

User-centered design

A design process that starts with the needs, experiences, and ideas of the people who will use a solution.

Climate anxiety

Worry or distress about climate change and its effects on the future.

Marginalized groups

Communities that have been pushed to the edges of society and excluded from decisions that affect them.

Words to Know · Centering Community Voices in Climate Solutions

Community engagement

Implementation science

User-centered design

Climate anxiety

Marginalized groups

Activity

Design Sprint for Your School

Students run a mini user-centered design workshop to address a climate-related issue at school.

Materials: Sticky notes; Markers; Chart paper divided into Listen, Define, Ideate, Test

1. Choose an issue, such as hot classrooms or anxiety about climate change.
2. Listen: interview three classmates about how the issue affects them and write each insight on a sticky note.
3. Define: group the notes and write one problem statement starting with 'How might we...'
4. Ideate: brainstorm at least five solutions, then choose one to sketch as a prototype.
5. Test: share your prototype with a different group and record their feedback. What would you change?

References

Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, C-CHANGE. Centering community voices in climate solutions. <https://hsph.harvard.edu/research/climate-health-c-change/research/centering-community-voices-in-climate-solutions/>